Completing Your RBIF

Completing your *Research Background Inquiry Form* (RBIF) is one of the most important steps in your petition process. The details you provide here will help us build compelling Petition Package documents and a strong, tailored case that highlights your unique background and contributions. You may first refer to the instructions on your RBIF tab. The following is an overview of the tab.

Main field

What to do:
In this section, type in the academic field that best represents your current and proposed research (e.g., "immunology," "computational modeling," "applied machine learning").

Why this matters:
Your field forms the core theme for your case, which should reflect where you have made, and will make, your most significant contributions.

Tips:

- Be specific, but not too narrow (e.g., "civil engineering" is a good field; "engineering" is too wide; and "finite element modeling of composite bridge joints" is too narrow).
- Make sure your chosen field matches your proposed endeavor (or your overall research goals) and can be supported by your past experience, degrees, and projects.
- If you are transitioning fields, pick one that connects your past work with your future goals.

CET Categories and Specializations

What to do:
In this section, please list up to three categories or subfields that are relevant to your work. If

possible, please list three Critical and Emerging Categories fields (and/or subfields). Please refer to the CET list here for ideas.

Why this matters:
These specializations help the USCIS identify what makes you unique. Additionally, they help us tailor your Petition Package documents so that they properly reflect you and your skills.

Tips:

- The fields or specializations you list here need to align with your main field and your proposed endeavor.
- Use CET categories if relevant. If they are not, it is fine to list other sub-areas.
- Make sure these specializations reflect your main achievements and future work.

Describe the Importance of Your Research

What to do:
In this section, please explain why your research matters: how it benefits your field, global issues, and especially the United States.

Why this matters:
This section proves the "national importance" of your work, a key requirement for NIW petitions.

Tips:

- Use plain language (avoid jargon).
- If possible, organize your answer using these prompts:
    - What problem are you addressing? Why is it urgent?
    - Who benefits from your work (e.g., U.S. industry, healthcare, government)?
    - How does your work align with U.S. priorities?

- You can cite government reports or strategies if relevant.
- Focus on your *current* and *future* research in the U.S.

Describe Up to Three Key Publications

What to do:
For up to three of your most important papers, please do the following:

- Provide the title, journal, and year of the paper.
- Write a 100-word summary of what you did.
- Write a short explanation of how this work advances your proposed endeavor.

Why this matters:
Your top publications are used throughout your petition to show your expertise, impact, and progress toward your goals.

Tips:

- Pick your most impactful, relevant works.
- Align your publication choices with your proposed endeavor.

Show How Others Have Used or Cited Your Work

What to do:
In this section, please describe up to three examples of independent researchers citing or using your work, including bibliographic info, brief description of their paper, and how they used your work.

Why this matters:
These examples prove your influence and recognition in your field.

Tips:

- Focus on citations from independent researchers, not researchers with whom you have co-authored a paper.
- If you do not have citations, list other examples of your work being utilized or implemented (e.g., in industry, government reports, curricula, or software).
- If you still don't have examples, describe the significance of your work.

Supplementary Information

a. Funding

What to do:
List any notable U.S.-based grants, awards, or funding you or your projects have received.

Why this matters:
Prestigious funding supports the significance and competitiveness of your work.

b. Prizes or Awards

What to do:
List any nationally or internationally recognized prizes or awards for your research.

Why this matters:
Major awards help demonstrate your impact and recognition.

c. Peer Review & Editorial Roles

What to do:
List any journals or conferences where you have served as a peer reviewer or on editorial boards.

Why this matters:
Review and editorial roles highlight your standing in the field.

d. Open-Source Contributions

What to do:
Describe open-source projects you have contributed to, including each project's name, your role in the project, and its impact.

Why this matters:
Open-source work can show broad impact, collaboration, and relevance to national priorities.

e. Additional Accomplishments

What to do:
Please share anything else important that has not been discussed elsewhere in the RBIF (e.g., leadership roles, memberships, media coverage, patents, high salary).

Why this matters:
Extra achievements give your case additional strength and show the full scope of your contributions.

General Tips for Completing Your RBIF

- When filling out the RBIF, remember that more detail is better!
- It is OK to use bullet points or fragments.
- Only include work or achievements you can support with documentation.
- Use the sample answers in the RBIF tab for inspiration.
- Do not worry about style. We will turn your input into polished legal documents.
- Ask questions. If anything is unclear, message us anytime.

After You Submit

When you finish, send us a quick message so we can review your answers. We will give you feedback and let you know if anything needs to be added or revised.

Thank you for your effort. Your RBIF helps us build the strongest case for your petition!